

THE SPECIALTY

All-inclusives, ranked. (Sort of.)

I've stayed at 20+ properties across the Caribbean and Mexico. Some are genuinely great. Most are mid. A few should be condemned. Here's what I know — and how I'd think about picking the right one for you.

20+	15+	6	100%
PROPERTIES STAYED	CARIBBEAN DESTINATIONS	BRAND FAMILIES	HONEST TAKES

THE LIST

The properties I've actually been to. The takes are real.

This isn't every all-inclusive I'd recommend — it's every one I've personally slept at. Names hyperlink to my full property notes (or DM me for the unfiltered version).

01	Excellence Playa Mujeres CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	The benchmark for adults-only in Mexico. Excellence Club is non-negotiable — private pool, premium liquor, butler. Don't book a base room or you'll feel ripped off.	SPECIALTY
02	Excellence Punta Cana DOMINICAN REPUBLIC • ADULTS ONLY	Bigger, livelier, less polished than Playa Mujeres. The food is solid. Get Excellence Club or genuinely don't bother.	RECOMMEND
03	Le Blanc Spa Resort Cancun CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	Sleek, modern, occasionally uptight. Great for honeymoon couples who hate kids and want a more "design hotel" feel.	RECOMMEND
04	Zoetry Agua Punta Cana DOMINICAN REPUBLIC • BOUTIQUE	Small, calm, almost wellness-led. The right pick if you want all-inclusive without the all-inclusive energy.	RECOMMEND
05	Atelier Playa Mujeres CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	Newer, ambitious, art-forward concept. Service still ironing out. Worth watching but I'd pick Excellence next door first.	CONDITIONAL
06	Hyatt Ziva Cap Cana DOMINICAN REPUBLIC • FAMILY	Best of the family-friendly DR options I've stayed at. Actual kids' programming that delivers. Adult zones genuinely quiet.	RECOMMEND
07	Secrets Cap Cana DOMINICAN REPUBLIC • ADULTS ONLY	Solid mid-tier adults-only. Preferred Club tier is worth the bump. Service is fine, food is fine, beach is fine. The whole place is fine.	CONDITIONAL
08	Dreams Riviera Cancun CANCUN • FAMILY	Reliable, established, accessible-luxury family resort. Beach has had sargassum issues. Get Preferred Club rooms.	CONDITIONAL
09	Royalton CHIC Punta Cana DOMINICAN REPUBLIC • ADULTS ONLY	Loud. Music until late. Party-resort energy. Fine if you're 22-30 and looking for that vibe. Otherwise the bass will end you.	SPECIFIC AUDIENCE
10	Sandals Royal Caribbean JAMAICA • ADULTS ONLY	If you're brand-loyal to Sandals, this is one of their better Jamaica properties. Otherwise, Excellence or Le Blanc gives you more for the same money.	CONDITIONAL
11	Sandals Curaçao CURAÇAO • ADULTS ONLY	Newer Sandals. Cleaner aesthetic than older Sandals properties. Curaçao itself is the better Sandals destination right now.	RECOMMEND
12	Beaches Turks & Caicos TURKS & CAICOS • FAMILY	Best beach of any all-inclusive I've been to. Premium family pricing — and you do feel it. Worth it for the beach alone.	RECOMMEND
13	Grand Velas Riviera Maya RIVIERA MAYA • FAMILY / ADULTS SECTIONS	Highest-end all-inclusive I've stayed at. Three sections (Ambassador / Zen / Grand Class). Pick Grand Class or skip — the others don't justify the price.	RECOMMEND
14	Rosewood Mayakoba RIVIERA MAYA • BOUTIQUE	Not strictly all-inclusive but with the right meal plan, functions like one. Highest aesthetic standard in the region. Worth the splurge for milestone trips.	RECOMMEND
15	Andaz Mayakoba RIVIERA MAYA • FAMILY FRIENDLY	Same Mayakoba complex as Rosewood but more accessible. Family-friendly, design-forward, the locals' favorite.	RECOMMEND
16	Nizuc Resort & Spa CANCUN • ADULTS / FAMILY	Architectural standout. The all-inclusive plan is optional. Worth it for honeymooners who want luxury without the resort-energy.	RECOMMEND
17	Unico 20'87 RIVIERA MAYA • ADULTS ONLY	Heavy concept (local cultural programming, no kids, no logo branding). Great for couples bored of standard all-inclusives. Beach is just okay.	RECOMMEND
18	+ a few more	A handful of properties I won't list publicly — including 2-3 I'd actively recommend against. Ask me on a call.	PRIVATELY

HOW I'D THINK ABOUT IT

The questions I ask before recommending a property. You should be asking these too.

Anyone can read the brochure. The right call depends on what you actually want, not on what marketing photos promise.

Adults-only, or kids in the equation? The biggest fork. Adults-only properties run quieter, slower, and usually serve better food. Family resorts have kids' clubs and waterslides but adult dinners get loud. There's no in-between; pick a side.	What's your noise tolerance? Yes, really. Royalton CHIC has DJs at the pool. Zoetry has acoustic guitar at the pool. Some people love one, some need the other. Marketing photos lie about this — I won't.
Mexico, Caribbean, or DR? Which trade-offs do you prefer? Mexico is fastest flight, sharpest design, best food, occasional sargassum. Caribbean is best beaches but limited supply at the top tier. DR is biggest variety and best value but more uneven service.	Club access or base room? The most common mistake. Most all-inclusives have a "Club" tier (Excellence Club, Preferred Club, etc.). The price difference is \$200-500/wk per couple. The amenity difference is enormous — private pools, premium liquor, butler, better food. Get Club.

COMMON MISTAKES

Four things people get wrong about booking all-inclusives. I see all of them every week.

01	Booking on Booking.com to save money. You don't save money. The hotel charges the same rate. You just lose the upgrades, club access, breakfast, credits, and human concierge that come with booking through an advisor. Average value left on the table: ~\$1,200 per couple per week.
02	Picking Sandals because it's famous. Sandals does heavy marketing. They're fine. They're often not the best option at their price point. Excellence Playa Mujeres, Le Blanc, and Royalton's adult-only properties typically deliver more for the same money. Tell your advisor your priorities first; let them recommend the brand, not the other way around.
03	Booking June through October in Riviera Maya. Sargassum season. Beaches are covered in brown seaweed for half the year. Hotels can clean it but you'll smell it from the lobby. If you must travel summer, go Caribbean (Turks, Anguilla, BVI) or Pacific Mexico. Nobody books for the resort. They book for the beach. The beach is the product.
04	Not booking Club / Preferred / Premium tier. The base room is bait pricing. The actual product is the Club tier. You'll spend \$5K either way; the question is whether you arrive to a basic room or to private-pool, premium liquor, butler service. If your budget is ~\$5K, book Club at a mid-tier resort. Better than base room at a top-tier resort.

Think you've picked your resort? Let me weigh in before you book.

20-minute call. Free. I'll tell you whether your shortlist is right, suggest 2-3 alternatives, and explain the room-tier trade-offs. No commitment.

Book a 20-min call →

Preface.

Travel for people who'd rather not Expedia it.

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